books in prison which were lost after they were smuggled out. A letter written from Lahore Central Jail on 24 July 1930 to Jaidev Gupta, who was a close school friend from boyhood days, implores him the latter to ‘take the following books in my name from Dwarkadas Library’ and have them sent to him through his younger brother, Kulvir, by the following Sunday.[5] The range of the books asked for is astonishing:

‘*Militarism* (Karl Liebknecht)	*Why Men Fight* (B. Russell)
Soviets at Work	*Collapse of the Second International*
Left-Wing Communism	*Mutual Aid* (Prince Kropotkin)
Fields. Factories and Workshops	*Civil War in France* (Marx)
Land Revolution in Russia	*Spy* (Upton Sinclair)’

To this list, Bhagat Singh added ‘one more book from Punjab Public Library: Historical Materialism (Bukharin)’ and asked ‘if some books have been sent to Borstal Jail’ because ‘[t]hey are facing a terrible famine of books’ as ‘[t]hey have not received any book till now’. He rounded off by demanding, ‘Also send *Punjab Peasants in Prosperity and Debt* by Malcolm Lyall Darling’.[6]

Bhagat Singh’s comrade Shiv Verma said of him, ‘No other revolutionary struck such deep rapport with the awakening people, no other became so endeared to the common people and youth as Bhagat Singh did.’ One reason for this was that ‘[a]s an intellectual Bhagat Singh was far superior to any of us’. For this reason, Navtej Singh writes that ‘he saw further than his comrades’ so that ‘it was at his suggestion and insistence that the word socialist was added to the name of the HRA, and the ideas of socialism, formulated in greater depth . . .’.[7]

Nevertheless, the extent of what Bhagat Singh wrote, from the time that he was taken prisoner on 8 April 1929 to the time that he was executed on 23 March 1931, remains contested. Indeed, it has entered into the realms of a make-believe world, populated by conjecture, supposition and even fantasy, to such an extent that it has today acquired a fabled and mythological life, all of its own. There is a reason for this. Take his four